And what are we to make of the supposed instance of the massacre of eight thousand Jains in Madurai? According to the Shaiva chronicles, this was perpetrated by a Pandyan king known as Koon Pandiyan, ‘the hunchback Pandyan’, who had abandoned Shaivism to embrace Jainism but was then restored to his original faith by one of the sixty-three Nayanars, a Shaiva boy saint named Sambandar, acting at the behest of his faithful queen. The Jains first set fire to Sambandar’s house, whereupon the saint deflected the fire at the king. The Jains were unable to alleviate the king’s suffering, whereas Sambandar not only removed the pain but also cured the king’s hunched back. Sambandar and the Jains then engaged in a series of wizardly challenges, from which the Shaiva saint emerged triumphant, whereupon the eight thousand Jains willingly allowed themselves to be impaled on stakes.

This supposed impaling of the Jains was until very recently depicted in frescoes on the walls surrounding the Golden Lily Tank of the Meenakshi Amman temple in Madurai. Yet not a hint of this catastrophic event can be found in any Jain chronicle, and they surely would have had most cause for complaint. The earliest known account of the Jain massacre comes from a twelfth-century Shaiva source, while the (now effaced) Lily Tank fresco dated from the seventeenth century. To me, this seems to be more a case of Shaiva triumphalism than anything else, a way of celebrating the success of Sambandar and his fellow Nayanars over the Jains in Madurai by making out that the Jains killed themselves in their humiliation.

As for Shankara’s alleged persecution of Buddhists, the plain facts are that Buddhism was losing popular support long before the advent of Shankara, while he himself was wise enough to learn from Buddhism even as he rejected its central philosophy, so much so that Shankara’s more orthodox opponents accused him of spreading Buddhism in